

Criminology as an Applied Social Science

Why do people commit crimes? Why do some societies have higher crime rates than others? How can crime be prevented, and how should offenders be treated? These questions lie at the heart of criminology. Criminology is not merely the study of criminals or the memorization of penal codes. It is an applied social science that draws from sociology, psychology, law, economics, and political science to understand crime – its causes, its consequences, and society's responses to it. Unlike casual speculation about crime, criminology uses systematic theories, rigorous research methods, and evidence-based practices to inform policing, courts, corrections, and crime prevention.

This reading material defines criminology as an applied social science, examines its key focus areas, explores major criminological theories, describes methods of criminological research, and outlines career pathways in criminology.

Part 1: Defining Criminology as an Applied Social Science

Criminology is a discipline that applies social science knowledge to real-world problems of crime and justice. It is not limited to catching criminals or enforcing laws.

Criminologists study why crime occurs, how society defines certain acts as criminal, how victims experience crime, and how institutions such as police, courts, and prisons respond to offenders. As an applied social science, criminology uses research to develop evidence-based policies and practices that reduce crime and improve justice.

What Is Criminology?

Criminology is the scientific study of crime, criminal behavior, the causes of crime, the social response to crime, and the systems of criminal justice. It is interdisciplinary, drawing from sociology (social causes of crime), psychology (individual criminal behavior), economics (costs of crime), political science (criminal law and policy), and law (legal procedures and rights).

Criminology as an Applied Social Science

Feature	Explanation
Draws on theory	Uses sociological, psychological, and economic theories to explain crime
Uses systematic methods	Applies research methods (surveys, statistics, case studies) to study crime patterns
Evidence-based	Informs policy and practice with research findings, not just tradition or opinion
Action-oriented	Aims to reduce crime, improve justice, and rehabilitate offenders
Interdisciplinary	Integrates knowledge from multiple social science disciplines

Criminology vs. Criminal Justice

Dimension	Criminology	Criminal Justice
Focus	Why crime occurs; causes and correlates of criminal behavior	How society responds to crime; operations of police, courts, corrections
Questions	Why do people commit crimes? What factors increase crime rates?	How effective is community policing? Do prisons reduce recidivism?
Methods	Theory development; statistical analysis; surveys	Program evaluation; policy analysis; institutional research
Outcome	Explanations of crime	Evaluation of crime control practices

Part 2: Key Focus Areas of Criminology

Criminologists study multiple dimensions of crime and justice. Each focus area asks different questions and uses different methods.

Focus Area	Questions Asked	Key Concepts
The Causes of Crime (Etiology)	Why do individuals commit crimes? What social, economic, or psychological factors increase criminal behavior?	Poverty, inequality, peer influence, family dysfunction, substance abuse, mental health, neighborhood conditions
The Nature and Extent of Crime (Criminal Statistics)	How much crime occurs? Where and when does crime happen? Which groups have higher crime rates?	Crime rates, victimization surveys, dark figure of crime (unreported crime), crime mapping
Typologies of Crime and Offenders	How do different types of crime differ? How do offenders differ across crime types?	Violent crime, property crime, organized crime, juvenile delinquency, serial offending, victimology
Social Responses to Crime	How do police, courts, and corrections respond to crime? What laws define certain acts as criminal?	Policing strategies, sentencing, incarceration, probation, parole, restorative justice
Crime Prevention and Control	What interventions reduce crime? How can communities prevent crime before it occurs?	Deterrence, rehabilitation, incapacitation, community policing, situational crime prevention

Victimology	Who is victimized by crime? What are the effects of victimization? How does the justice system treat victims?	Victim precipitation, victim impact statements, victim compensation, fear of crime
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Part 3: Major Criminological Theories

Criminological theories explain why crime occurs. Different theories emphasize different factors: individual traits, social environment, rational choice, or power structures.

Classical and Rational Choice Theories

Classical Theory (Cesare Beccaria, Jeremy Bentham)

- *Core Idea:* People have free will and make rational choices. Crime occurs when the perceived benefits outweigh the perceived costs (punishment).
- *Key Concepts:* Deterrence, proportionality (punishment should fit the crime), swiftness and certainty of punishment
- *Policy Implications:* Clear laws; predictable, proportionate punishments; crime prevention through increasing perceived risk of getting caught

Rational Choice Theory

- *Core Idea:* Offenders weigh the risks, rewards, and effort of a crime before deciding to commit it.
- *Key Concepts:* Cost-benefit analysis; situational factors; opportunity
- *Policy Implications:* Increase effort (locks, alarms); increase risk (surveillance, police presence); reduce rewards (marking property, cashless transactions)

Biological and Psychological Theories

Biological Theories

- *Core Idea:* Genetic, neurological, and biochemical factors predispose some individuals to criminal behavior.
- *Key Concepts:* Genetics (twin studies); brain abnormalities; hormones; nutrition
- *Limitations:* Cannot explain most crime; risk of biological determinism; ethical concerns

Psychological Theories

- *Core Idea:* Personality, cognitive development, and mental disorders influence criminal behavior.
- *Key Concepts:* Antisocial personality disorder; low impulse control; moral development (Kohlberg); psychopathy
- *Policy Implications:* Early intervention; mental health treatment; cognitive-behavioral therapy for offenders

Sociological Theories

Social Disorganization Theory (Chicago School)

- *Key Thinkers:* Shaw and McKay
- *Core Idea:* Crime is highest in neighborhoods with poverty, population turnover, and racial/ethnic heterogeneity. Weak social institutions (schools, families, community organizations) cannot control crime.
- *Key Concepts:* Concentrated poverty; collective efficacy (neighborhood willingness to intervene for the common good); broken windows theory
- *Policy Implications:* Community development; improving schools and housing; community policing; youth programs

Strain Theory (Robert Merton)

- *Core Idea:* Crime occurs when there is a gap between culturally approved goals (wealth, success) and legitimate means to achieve them (education, employment). Individuals adapt through innovation (crime), retreatism (substance abuse), or rebellion.
- *Key Concepts:* Anomie; goal-means gap; adaptation
- *Policy Implications:* Expand legitimate opportunities (job training, education); reduce inequality

Differential Association Theory (Edwin Sutherland)

- *Core Idea:* Criminal behavior is learned through interaction with others who define crime favorably. Learning includes techniques of crime and motives/drives.
- *Key Concepts:* Frequency, duration, priority, and intensity of associations; definitions favorable or unfavorable to crime
- *Policy Implications:* Disrupt criminal networks; provide pro-social peer groups; positive role models

Labeling Theory (Howard Becker, Edwin Lemert)

- *Core Idea:* Deviance is not inherent in an act but is a label applied by society. Being labeled a "criminal" can lead to secondary deviance (further crime) as the person internalizes the label.
- *Key Concepts:* Primary deviance (initial rule-breaking); secondary deviance (deviance after labeling); self-fulfilling prophecy; moral panic
- *Policy Implications:* Avoid formal processing for minor offenses (diversion programs); restorative justice; decriminalization of victimless crimes; against stigmatizing offenders

Social Control Theory (Travis Hirschi)

- *Core Idea:* People do not commit crimes because they are bonded to society. Weak bonds increase crime risk.
- *Key Concepts:* Four elements of the bond: attachment (to family, school), commitment (to conventional goals), involvement (in conventional activities), belief (in moral order)
- *Policy Implications:* Strengthen family, school, and community attachments; after-school programs; mentoring

Critical and Conflict Theories

Conflict Theory (Karl Marx)

- *Core Idea:* Crime is defined by those in power to protect their interests. Laws reflect the interests of the ruling class. The poor are more likely to be labeled criminal because they lack power.
- *Key Concepts:* Power; class struggle; selective enforcement; criminalization of the poor
- *Policy Implications:* Reduce economic inequality; reform laws that serve powerful interests; decriminalize poverty-related behaviors

Feminist Criminology

- *Core Idea:* Traditional criminology has ignored women – both as offenders and as victims. Gender inequality shapes crime and justice.
- *Key Concepts:* Victimization of women (domestic violence, sexual assault); pathways to crime (trauma, abuse); gender bias in courts and corrections
- *Policy Implications:* Respond seriously to violence against women; gender-responsive programs for female offenders; eliminate bias in sentencing

Part 4: Methods of Criminological Research

Criminologists do not rely on intuition or media reports. They use systematic, scientific methods to collect and analyze data about crime patterns, test theories, and evaluate crime prevention programs. Different methods serve different purposes: some measure how much crime occurs, others explore why individuals commit crimes, and still others test whether interventions actually work. Each method has strengths and limitations, and skilled criminologists choose the method that best answers their research question.

Major Research Methods

Official Crime Statistics (Uniform Crime Reports)

- *Description:* Data collected by police on crimes reported to or detected by law enforcement
- *Strengths:* Large-scale; standardized; available over long time periods
- *Limitations:* Only includes reported crime; influenced by reporting practices; dark figure of crime (unreported crime)

Victimization Surveys (e.g., National Crime Victimization Survey)

- *Description:* Surveys asking individuals about crimes they have experienced, whether reported to police or not
- *Strengths:* Captures unreported crime; includes detailed victim information
- *Limitations:* Relies on memory; does not cover all crime types; excludes homicide

Self-Report Surveys

- *Description:* Anonymous surveys asking individuals to report crimes they have committed
- *Strengths:* Captures undetected crime; useful for studying juvenile delinquency
- *Limitations:* May underreport serious crime; honesty of respondents

Experimental and Quasi-Experimental Research

- *Description:* Testing crime prevention programs by comparing treatment (program participants) and control (non-participants) groups
- *Example:* Does a job training program reduce recidivism among released prisoners?
- *Strengths:* Can establish cause and effect
- *Limitations:* Ethical constraints; practical difficulties

Crime Mapping (Geographic Information Systems)

- *Description:* Using GIS to map crime locations and identify spatial patterns (hot spots)
- *Strengths:* Visual; identifies high-crime areas for targeted policing
- *Limitations:* Does not explain why crime occurs in certain locations

Qualitative Methods (Interviews, Ethnography)

- *Description:* In-depth interviews or extended observation of offenders, victims, or criminal justice professionals
 - *Strengths:* Rich detail; captures meaning and lived experience
 - *Limitations:* Small samples; cannot generalize to larger population
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Part 5: Career Pathways in Criminology

Criminology graduates work in law enforcement, courts, corrections, victim services, research, and policy.

Major Career Pathways

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks	Example Positions
Law Enforcement	Police departments, investigative agencies (NBI, PNP)	Crime prevention and investigation; intelligence analysis; community relations	Police officer, detective, crime analyst, NBI agent
Corrections	Prisons, jails, probation and parole offices, halfway houses	Supervising incarcerated individuals; case management; rehabilitation programming	Correctional officer, probation officer, parole officer, correctional counselor
Courts and Legal System	Prosecution, public defense, courts, victim-witness programs	Case preparation; legal research; victim support; pretrial services	Paralegal, victim advocate, pretrial services officer, court administrator

Career Path	Work Setting	Typical Tasks	Example Positions
Juvenile Justice	Juvenile detention centers, youth courts, family services, group homes	Supervising juvenile offenders; case management; intervention programs	Juvenile probation officer, youth counselor, diversion program coordinator
Victim Services	Non-profits, government victim assistance, shelters, rape crisis centers	Crisis intervention; emotional support; advocacy; linking victims to resources	Victim advocate, crisis hotline counselor, shelter coordinator
Research and Policy	Universities, research institutes, government agencies, think tanks	Research on crime patterns; evaluating prevention programs; writing policy briefs	Criminologist, crime analyst, policy researcher, program evaluator
Security and Loss Prevention	Private corporations, retail stores, security firms	Preventing theft; security audits; investigating internal crimes; risk assessment	Loss prevention specialist, corporate security manager,

Criminology in the Philippines

Information	Details
Regulatory body	Professional Regulatory Board of Criminology (under PRC)
Licensure exam	Criminologist Licensure Examination

Information

Details

Major
employers

Philippine National Police (PNP), Bureau of Jail Management and Penology (BJMP), Bureau of Corrections (BuCor), National Bureau of Investigation (NBI), local government units, private security agencies

Professional
organization

Philippine College of Criminology (PCCr) and Professional Criminologists Association of the Philippines (PCAP)

Key Terms

Term	Definition
Criminology	The scientific study of crime, criminal behavior, causes of crime, and society's response to crime
Victimology	The study of crime victims, their experiences, and the effects of victimization
Dark figure of crime	Unreported crime that does not appear in official statistics
Deterrence	The use of punishment to discourage criminal behavior
Recidivism	Relapse into criminal behavior after conviction or release from incarceration
Restorative justice	An approach focusing on repairing harm caused by crime, involving victims, offenders, and community
Collective efficacy	A community's willingness to intervene for the common good
Labeling theory	Theory that deviance is a label applied by society, which can increase further deviance
Criminal justice system	The network of police, courts, and corrections that respond to crime

Review Questions

1. Define criminology as an applied social science. How does criminology differ from criminal justice?
2. List three major focus areas of criminology. For each, state one question criminologists ask.
3. Identify three major criminological theories. For each theory, state the core idea and one policy implication.
4. Explain the difference between Classical Theory (Beccaria) and Social Disorganization Theory (Shaw and McKay). Which level of analysis do they focus on (individual, community, society)?
5. What is the "dark figure of crime"? Why is it a limitation of official crime statistics?
6. Describe two methods of criminological research. For each, state one strength and one limitation.
7. List three career pathways in criminology. For each, state the work setting and one typical task.
8. What is Labeling Theory? Explain the difference between primary deviance and secondary deviance.
9. What are the four elements of Hirschi's Social Control Theory? How do they prevent crime?
10. Application question: A neighborhood has high rates of property crime (theft, burglary). Using Social Disorganization Theory, explain why crime is high in this neighborhood. Then, using Crime Prevention Through Environmental Design (increased effort, increased risk, reduced rewards), propose three specific interventions that could reduce crime in this neighborhood.